Hindi journalist Brijesh Shukla, who has covered UP BJP's politics for three decades. 'The earlier BJP was full of swarans (upper castes) such as Brahmins, Baniyas and Thakurs. When Narendra Modi got command of the party, he completely inverted its structure. The new BJP does not focus on swarans. Swarans come to it in [the] name of nationalism. It focuses on getting backwards, smaller castes, poor: these are the people BJP has focused its attention on since 2014 and they became its new "Sanjeevani" [the life-saving divine herb that Hanuman used in the Ramayana to revive an injured Lakshman after he had been near-fatally injured in battle] before 2019.'[13]

Of course, the early BJP in the 1980s and the '90s was also built on the shoulders of OBC leaders like the party's first chief minister in UP, Kalyan Singh, in whose tenure (1991-92) the Babri Masjid was demolished; Uma Bharti, its first chief minister in Madhya Pradesh (2003-04); and former Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) leader Shivraj Singh Chouhan, a five-time MP from Vidisha who later became the BJP's longest-serving chief minister in Madhya Pradesh (2005–2018, and again from 2020). Their rise epitomised the BJP's political response to the caste-based Mandal agitation of the early 1990s, which became the crucible of a number of caste-based political parties like SP (led by Yadavs), BSP (led by Dalits), RJD (Yadavs in Bihar) and several others. OBCs were in the vanguard of the BJP's rise in that period, which was characterised by what became known as the politics of 'Kamandal' (Hindutva) versus 'Mandal'. BJP sought to draw those lower down in the caste hierarchy into a larger identity predicated on a united Hinduness. Caste-based parties, on the other hand, sought to give them political representation outside of the erstwhile mainstream parties, arguing that they would never have a fair share within the old framework. The challenge for the BJP was to combine the forces of 'Kamandal' and 'Mandal' while also incorporating the Dalit leader and Constitution-maker B.R. Ambedkar as an icon in its own pantheon. Its stagnation from the late-1990s was linked to an inability to balance these competing imperatives. The BJP's decline in UP in the 2000s, in that sense, was directly linked to losing its incipient support and leadership base among OBCs, which had been at the centre of